

Avatar and Background

Link: <https://pinterest.com/pin/450641506481412689/>

This particular image of Darth Vader is the one I will be analyzing for this exercise. In the Star Wars canon, Vader is one of the most prominent examples of a tragic hero; born Anakin Skywalker a mighty Jedi, he turns to the dark side in a desperate attempt to save those he loved, only to lose them, and be physically destroyed. His terrifying cybernetic armor, which provides the only thing keeping him alive and breathing, makes him the brutal enforcer of the Galactic Empire, he is a walking contradiction, with tremendous, terrifying power and yet with deep human vulnerability under the surface.

Connection to "The Self"

Vader connects to two key concepts of the self: the ideal self and the shadow self. On one hand, the commanding power of Vader and his physical bearing tap into an ideal self of one that is confident, impervious to outside stress, and commands instant respect. On the other hand, Vader serves as the shadow self; a repressed frustration, anger, and perhaps even the negative emotions that one has to hold away from polite society.

Reason for Identification

I connect to Vader through wishful identification primarily; defined by the lecture as the desire to be a particular way. Though I don't want to be an evil space dictator, I identify through wishful identification when it comes to his control and how people instantly respond to him. I connect through similarity identification as well; I identify with him on the principle that sometimes we can be stuck by a situation, or that we must face consequences for our mistakes.

Aspects Compelling Identification

The two aspects that made me want to identify with him are empathy and embodiment. With his back story and the physical pain that he is constantly enduring due to his mechanical body (lore makes it obvious you're meant to feel bad for the man inside the mask), it's very easy to feel for Vader. Embodiment is also compelling when looking at him; it is extremely easy to imagine how his

heavy mechanical breathing and heavy dark armor could make you feel embodied in a physically imposing form.

Identity Expression and Exploration

Finally, this Avatar allows for an interesting and positive identity expression in that it allowed me to explore issues of power and resilience in a safe way. This allows a part of me to explore and express power that might usually have to be suppressed in my day-to-day, academic-centered life. It also explores the idea that you can reinvent yourself and who you are, just as Vader can achieve a degree of redemption in the end.